

# RIZWAN ZAFAR

## PAYMENTS PRODUCT AND PROGRAM EXECUTIVE | FINTECH INFRASTRUCTURE

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### PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Payments product and program executive with 17 years across complex technology and delivery environments. Currently Chief Product Officer at Simpaisa, leading product across payment gateway, pay-in, payout, cross-border, merchant onboarding, settlement, risk and compliance. Simpaisa publicly reports more than \$1B in annual GTV, 270M annual transactions, 150+ merchants and formal operations in five markets. Brings product judgment together with PMO discipline, partner management and regulated delivery.

### IMPACT SNAPSHOT

|            |                 |              |               |
|------------|-----------------|--------------|---------------|
| \$1B+      | 270M+           | 5            | 40            |
| ANNUAL GTV | PAYMENTS / YEAR | LIVE MARKETS | ENGINEERS LED |

### CORE COMPETENCIES

|                            |                                                                                                                                                         |
|----------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| PAYMENTS<br>INFRASTRUCTURE | Gateway and orchestration   pay-in and payout APIs   card acquiring   wallets   DCB   IBFT   cross-border and FX   settlement and reconciliation        |
| PRODUCT LEADERSHIP         | Strategy and roadmaps   platform operating models   merchant onboarding   pricing and unit economics   partner enablement   product organization design |
| RISK AND CONTROLS          | KYC and KYB   AML and CFT   sanctions screening   fraud controls   chargebacks   PCI DSS   ISO 27001   audit readiness                                  |
| PROGRAM DELIVERY           | PMO governance   SteerCo and board reporting   OKRs   RAID management   vendor governance   multi-market launches   transformation programs             |

### PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

#### Chief Product Officer (acting CTO, 2024) | Simpaisa

Dubai | Aug 2020 - Present

- Own product strategy and roadmaps across payment gateway, pay-in, payout and cross-border product lines, working with executive, engineering, operations, risk and commercial teams.
- Built and scaled card acquiring, mobile-wallet, DCB, IBFT, voucher, bill-payment, QR, tokenization, payout and cross-border capabilities with local and global partners.
- Designed merchant onboarding across self-service flows, automated KYC and KYB, risk-tiered approval and category-based pricing for a platform serving 150+ merchants.
- Established product controls across fraud prevention, chargebacks, AML and CFT, transaction monitoring, settlement and reconciliation; supported PCI DSS Level 1 and ISO 27001 programs.
- Led multi-market expansion and platform delivery through a regulatory transition while carrying dual product and technology leadership responsibilities during 2024.
- Built the product organization from 2 to 8 product managers and led cross-functional delivery across product, engineering, operations, risk and compliance.

#### Project Manager, Payments Operations | Daraz (Alibaba Group)

Karachi | Mar 2020 - Aug 2020

- Ran payments operations and delivery governance across Pakistan, Bangladesh, Sri Lanka, Nepal and Myanmar during the COVID-driven volume surge.
- Coordinated reconciliation, settlement, payment compliance, fraud-rule management and vendor delivery across country teams.

## PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE, CONTINUED

### Senior Product and Program Manager | Tapmad

Karachi | Jul 2017 - Mar 2020

- Owned OTT monetization and billing strategy; launched direct carrier billing across Pakistan's four major telecom operators and expanded wallet and card payment options.
- Led migration from high-cost carrier billing toward wallet and card rails, improving payment economics and subscription flexibility.

## EARLIER PROGRAM AND PMO LEADERSHIP

### PMO and Project Manager | Wing Logic

Dubai | Apr 2017 - Oct 2017

- Established PMO governance, portfolio reporting, risk tracking and executive cadence for a multi-project technology and engineering portfolio.

### Assistant Manager, Projects | CIMKO / Nyumba Ya Akiba

DR Congo | May 2016 - Jan 2017

- Managed ERP and IT infrastructure initiatives in a greenfield industrial environment, coordinating vendors, procurement, schedule and operational handover.

### Project Manager, PMO | DS Engineering Services

Karachi | Sep 2012 - Feb 2016

- Managed engineering-project portfolios and built reporting, controls and delivery governance across utilities and infrastructure programs.

### Senior Planning Engineer | PESCO

Karachi | Jun 2009 - Aug 2012

- Planned and monitored power-infrastructure work, establishing the reliability and operational discipline that later shaped fintech product leadership.

## EDUCATION

**MIT Sloan School of Management** - Executive Program, Mastering Design Thinking (2022)

**University of Karachi** - M.Sc. Physics (2012); B.Sc. Physics (2009)

## CERTIFICATIONS

Project Management Professional (PMP), PMI | PMI Agile Certified Practitioner (PMI-ACP) | Certified Scrum Product Owner (CSPO) | Certified ScrumMaster (CSM) | COBIT 5 Foundation | ITIL v3 Foundation

## SELECTED PROFESSIONAL FOCUS

- VP, Head or Director of Product - Payments Infrastructure
- Product leadership for payment networks, PSPs, acquiring, cross-border and regulated fintech
- Program and transformation leadership where product, controls, partners and delivery must operate as one system

## PORTFOLIO AND CONTACT

Selected work and payments writing: [rzifi.com](https://rzifi.com)

Book a 15-minute introduction: [cal.com/rizwan-zafar-gws2uk/15min](https://cal.com/rizwan-zafar-gws2uk/15min)